

#### < PIERCED PREY

Most fish-eating birds grasp prey in their bills, but anhingas are spear-fishers, piercing small fish with the upper mandible, and larger ones with both.

↔ 34–35 in (86–89 cm)

⚖ 3 lb (1.4 kg)

⊗ Common

🐟 Fish

🏠 



# Great blue heron

*Ardea herodias*

black shoulder patches

long, narrow toes



The great blue heron is the largest wading bird in North America. Herons worldwide have a similar long neck, curled back between the shoulders in flight or when the bird is resting, but stretched out to grab a passing fish with a lightning strike of the long, sharp bill. Great blue herons are masters of “wait-and-watch” predation and patient stalking,

standing like shadowy statues in the shallows for hours. They can be surprisingly aerobic around their treetop colonies, where up to six eggs are incubated for 27 days. The chicks are fed by both parents for up to 80 days before they can fly. One subspecies, *A. h. occidentalis*, occurs in a pure white form in Florida.

↔ 3–5 ft (0.9–1.5 m)

⚖ 5–6 lb (2.3–2.7 kg)

⊗ Common

🐟 Fish, frogs, birds

🏠 



#### < HIGH LIFE

Great blue herons build their nests high on trees, safe from ground predators. They must be substantial enough for several chicks to grow to full size.

# Purple gallinule

*Porphyrio martinica*

long, yellow legs and toes



Combining ease of movement on land and on floating leaves with the ability to swim like a duck, the gallinule is a waterside all-rounder that lives in tropical wetlands. It prefers dense vegetation with open channels and ditches. Its dishlike nest, made

of grasses on a floating mat of weed or attached to reed stems, contains up to 10 eggs, which hatch after 20 days. The chicks feed themselves after a week, become independent three weeks later, and fly when five to seven weeks old.

#### > QUICK STEPPER

The gallinule spreads its weight through its elongated toes and steps quickly and rhythmically across floating vegetation. It also often climbs up more awkwardly through dense twigs.



↔ 11–14 in (28–36 cm)

⚖ 7–10 oz (200–284 g)

⊗ Common

🐟 Seeds, fruit, invertebrates

🏠 

